

Hero Companion

Help & Release Notes — your City of Heroes sidekick

App version 0.12.10 · Model v24 · Game database 2026.1.1242

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Hero Companion is a fan-made build planner for City of Heroes: Homecoming. It plans, optimizes, and walks you through character builds using the game's actual math — to-hit, resistance, defense, endurance, recharge — not templates or guesswork. It runs entirely on your own computer, next to (never inside) the game.

Quick Start

Open the app and pick one of the entry cards:

- **Build a new level 50** — you choose archetype, powersets, the content you'll run, and your role on a team; the optimizer designs a complete end-game build with enhancement slotting.
- **Start from scratch (level 1)** — same choices, but you get a level-by-level leveling companion that walks every pick and slot from 1 to 50.
- **Import from Mids Reborn** — paste a Mids build (or load a .mbd file) and the tool evaluates it, then can optimize from there.
- **Import a character you play** — type `/build_save_file`` in game, then click "Find my characters for me": the tool locates your Homecoming saves itself and imports the one you pick. (Unusual install location? Tell it your game folder once and it remembers.)

Everything is reversible. Nothing you click is permanent, and in-game a `/respec` rewrites any character anyway.

The Build Panel

Pick your archetype, primary, and secondary. The panel fills with your powers; click a power to add or remove it, and use the slot controls to place enhancement slots (the game grants 67 placeable slots across a career; the tool enforces the real limits).

The stat panel updates live: defense by position, resistance by type, recharge, recovery, damage. Caps are shown — defense soft cap 45%, resistance cap by archetype.

Content and Role

These two dropdowns are the most important choice in the tool:

- **Content** — what you actually run: general play, task forces, incarnate trials, fire farms, PvP. It sets what the build must survive and deliver.
- **Role** — what you're there to do: damage, tank, buff/debuff support, control,

healing. The optimizer maximizes your role output, not a generic score.

A support character is scored on how much its debuffs and buffs actually change fights (magnitude times uptime), not on its own survival. That's deliberate: the tool builds characters that are noticed as contributors.

The Optimizer

The "Optimize" actions run a real search over powers, pools, and slotting:

- It explores every legal add, drop, and swap — including all power pools — and runs until no single change improves the build (with honest certificates saying so).
- It respects the game's rules: pool limits (four max), the origin-pool rule (only one of Sorcery / Experimentation / Force of Will / Gadgetry / Utility Belt), archetype set access, prerequisite tiers, and level availability.
- It learns: strong past results seed future searches as champions.

If a suggestion looks odd, it earned its place in the math — but you always have the final say. Swap anything; the tool re-evaluates around your choices.

Leveling from 1 to 50

For from-scratch characters, the leveling walk shows exactly what happens at every level on the real Homecoming schedule: a power on even levels, slots on odd levels, pools at 4, epics at 35, respec trials at 24/34/44, and cost-smart enhancement advice for each stretch (cheap early, common IOs from 7, sets near the end).

You can take every suggestion or none of them. The walk tracks where you've deviated and offers to re-fit the end-game around your actual choices.

Kheldians (Peacebringer / Warshade)

Kheldians follow their own rules and the tool knows it: inherent flight from level 1 (no travel pool needed unless you want one), Nova and Dwarf forms inside your own power sets, and no epic pool at all — the walk and the wizard both reflect that.

Arachnos Soldiers and Widows

VEATs live a two-phase career and the walk follows it honestly:

- **Levels 1–23:** only your base sets (Arachnos Soldier / Training and Gadgets, or Widow Training / Teamwork) — branch powers can't be taken yet, so the walk never suggests them.
- **Level 24:** the mandatory respec. You choose your branch — Crab or Bane, Night Widow or Fortunata — and re-place every pick from level 1 with all six sets open. The walk hands you the complete re-place order right at this step.
- **Levels 24–50:** the walk continues from the respec order, branch powers included.

Enhancement Converter and Haul Appraiser

The Converter panel answers two questions:

- **"How do I get this IO cheaply?"** — a concrete cheapest path per enhancement: which piece to buy or craft, which converters to use, and the converter/merit cost. One rule of the game worth knowing: conversions can't jump from cheap pools into purples — the tool's paths never pretend otherwise.
- **"Is this drop worth anything?"** — paste your drops (recipes included, straight from the game). Each item gets a verdict: keep for your build, craft-then-convert for profit, or just sell.

Saving, Importing, Exporting

- **Save** keeps the character's plan and leveling progress locally so you can resume. Auto-save runs in the background.
- **Import/Export** is Mids Reborn compatible — bring builds in, take builds out. Your builds are yours; nothing leaves your machine.

Hero or Villain

The alignment button in the banner reskins the whole app — Hero Companion in blue, Villain Companion in red. Pure style; your choice is remembered.

Bugs, Champions, and Updates

Hero Companion is a living tool, and you're part of how it improves. Three buttons, all strictly opt-in — the app never sends anything on its own:

- **Report a bug** — opens a pre-filled bug report on the project's GitHub page with your app, model, and game-data versions already included (that's usually the hard part of a good bug report). Add what happened and post it. Nothing is sent until you click submit on GitHub itself.
- **Submit champion** — think your current build beats the shipped champion for its archetype and role? This saves your build as a *champion candidate* file and opens the submission queue. The development hub re-scores every candidate with its own math — if your build genuinely wins, it becomes the new shipped champion in a future update, with credit to you.
- **check for updates** (bottom of the page) — compares your version against the latest release on GitHub. On first run the app asks once whether to do this check automatically at startup (it contacts github.com to compare version numbers and sends nothing else); say yes and new releases greet you with an "Update now / Remind me later" banner. Say no and the footer button is the only check that ever runs. Updates are never downloaded or installed for you.

A few words the tool uses precisely: a **champion** is the best certified build for an archetype + powersets + role combination — champions ship with the app and give the optimizer its head start. A **candidate** is your claim to beat one. The ****model version**** (v23 today) stamps which generation of the scoring physics produced a number, and the **data version** stamps which game database it was computed against — so

scores are always compared apples to apples.

Frequently Asked

The tool and the game disagree — who's right? The game, always. The tool's model is verified against the Homecoming Wiki and City of Data, but patches happen. When you find a disagreement, that's a bug worth reporting.

****Why won't it give me a second origin pool / a branch power at level 10 / an epic on my Peacebringer?****
Because the game won't allow it. The tool only suggests choices that exist for your character at that level.

Does it play the game for me? No. It never touches the game client or servers. It's a planner you read while you play.

Is it free? Free and noncommercial, forever (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). See the Terms of Use, License, and Credits links at the bottom of the app.

Credits

Built on the work of the City of Heroes community: NCSoft (the game, all rights theirs), Homecoming Servers, Mids Reborn (all game data, parsed from your own install), the Unofficial Homecoming Wiki, City of Data v2, the Homecoming Forums, the Paragon Wiki Archive — and Guyver [SoV] of the Sovereign supergroup, whose openly shared master builds were the standard this tool's optimizer had to honestly beat.

Hero Companion — What's New

0.12.10 — July 6, 2026

- **Pet summons are slotted for the pet now.** A summon power — Mastermind henchmen, a controller or Arachnos pet, Gang War, Phantom Army — was sometimes being used as a parking spot for the player's own always-on healing IOs (Numina, Miracle, Panacea) instead of a set that actually helps the pet. Those healing IOs belong in Health, where they buff you, so that's where they go now. Every pet summon is reserved for a real pet set — its accuracy, damage, and the pet enhancement bonuses (and the Mastermind archetype IOs) — and is forced to take one rather than sitting on filler. Thanks again to Maelwys for the example. Deeper slotting quality (procs versus full sets by attack, minus-resistance procs, when recharge in a summon actually matters) is still being tuned.

0.12.9 — July 6, 2026

- **Game data brought current.** Our numbers came from a Mids database that turned out to be about six months old, so recent balance patches were missing. We now reality-check against the live game and fixed everything that had drifted: the Brute, Sentinel, Tanker, and Dominator defense/resist/damage modifiers (this is why Brute defense was reading low), a batch of power endurance/recharge/range values, and slotting rules — including Mastermind archetype IOs now being slottable in personal attacks. Set bonuses were checked and are current. Thanks to Maelwys on the Homecoming forums for catching the stale data.

- **The slotting tags now show on any build, not just after Solve.** Resume or import a build and each power shows why it's slotted the way it is (full set / proc bomb / global mules) right away — previously those tags only appeared right after solving, which made a loaded build look like the update hadn't taken.

- **Respec worksheet.** When you resume a build with slots not earning set bonuses, a small bar appears at the top of the build — "Ready for respec?" — that opens the full plan as a pop-up (so it's there when you want it, out of the way when you don't). The plan shows every change power by power — the old slotting struck through, the new below it — the stat gains, and a grocery list split two ways: what to craft or buy, and what to unslot and sell (with a note on each item's worth). Every line has a checkbox to track your progress, and the whole thing is saved to the character, so you can work it over several sessions of crafting (the bar shows "N/M done"). Apply it to your build when ready, Undo to revert, or mark it completed. It never appears on a build that's already well slotted.

- **Explanations everywhere.** The slotting tags (proc bomb, full set, frankenslot, global mules) and the respec card now have a ? that opens a plain-language explanation of what the term means, why that approach is used, and your options — including why, for example, a frankenslot can beat a single six-piece set.

- **Updating no longer leaves a ghost tray icon, for real this time.** When the app updates itself, it now removes its own tray icon cleanly before the installer takes over, instead of being

force-killed and leaving a dead icon behind that only clears when you mouse over it. (0.12.8 improved this for extra copies; this closes the main path — the app replacing itself.)

0.12.8 — July 6, 2026

- **Watch multiple accounts at once — per-character stat cards.** Dual-boxers can now tick more than one account, and the Play Log shows a card per character side by side (Rattle's kills and haul next to your farmer's), each with its own fit link. Accounts are toggle chips — click to add or remove one from what's watched.
- **The Play Log moved up into the main workspace.** Instead of a detached strip far below everything, it now docks in the wide build column — filling that space when no build is loaded, and sitting neatly under the build when one is. On narrow screens it still stacks full-width like the rest.
- **Cleaner haul advice.** Incarnate salvage and crafting materials no longer get a "KEEP" tag — there's no decision to make (you bank them and spend later), so the haul now saves its keep/sell verdicts for the drops that actually warrant one (enhancement recipes and salvage). Incarnate materials are still counted in your loot summary.
- **The Play Log now knows who you're playing — and links to their fit.** It reads the character name from the log ("playing Rattle") instead of only showing the account, tracks it across character switches, and attributes your stats to the right character. If that character has a saved build in Hero Companion, a one-click **"load their fit"** link appears — so switching from Rattle to Lime Juice brings up Lime Juice's build, not whoever you had open. (The game only names your character on a fresh login, so if it says "not detected yet," log out to character select and back in.) Because players sometimes rename characters, the fit link is one you can set explicitly — "link the open fit to this character" — so it sticks through a rename and fixes any wrong name-guess. No fit for a character yet? It offers to import their build straight from the game.
- **The Play Log's account switch is now obvious.** Which account you're watching shows as a row of chips (the active one highlighted with), and switching is one click on another chip — no more hunting for a "change account" link. For dual-boxers this matters: each account is its own log, so you flip between your two characters' stats instantly, and a note says so.
- **Your farm haul now knows your build.** When the Play Log is watching a character that has a saved fit, any drop whose set your build actually uses gets starred and floated to the top of the haul as a **"keep — for your build,"** naming the power that wants it. A standard set you would normally vendor becomes a keep when it is in your plan. Drops that do not fit still get the usual keep-or-sell advice.
- **Every power now explains how it is slotted.** Each power in a generated or solved build wears a small tag saying *why* it is slotted the way it is — a full set for its bonuses, a proc bomb (more AoE damage than a set here), global mules (uniques that each work from one slot), or a deliberate frankenslot. Hover it for the full reasoning. High-end slotting can look like scatter until you know the plan; now the build tells you the plan.

- **Fixed some warnings that were plain wrong.** The off-role check used to tell a Brute or Mastermind its powers "do not extend to damage dealer," which is nonsense — those are damage dealers and are now recognized as such. The "no damage enhancement" warning no longer fires on a power that is carrying a real set of damage procs. And Physical Perfection (and the epic-pool tier rules around it) now require the correct number of prerequisite powers, verified against a large corpus of real builds.
- **Better proc choices.** When the optimizer proc-bombs a power, it now ranks the available procs by actual expected damage, so the strongest procs land instead of whichever the data happened to list first.
- **The tray icon behaves.** Updating no longer leaves a "ghost" tray icon that only clears when you mouse over it — the old copy now shuts down cleanly and removes its own icon before the new one takes over. The tray menu also gains **Check for updates...** (it tells you right there whether a new version is out) alongside Open and Quit. Hero Companion keeps running in the tray after you close the browser tab so reopening is instant; the tray menu is how you drive or quit it.

0.12.7 — July 5, 2026

- **The Play Log parser is now built on real logs.** The first cut guessed at line formats; this version is validated against tens of thousands of lines of actual Homecoming chat logs. It reads XP and influence, enemies defeated (a real kill count), every drop sorted into recipes / salvage / incarnate materials / crafting mats with keep-or-sell advice, and Consignment House sales and purchases — while correctly ignoring the wall of combat, heal, and chat spam around them. Recipe drops map to their enhancement set for a proper verdict. (Veteran levels aren't written to the chat log by the game, so post-50 progress is shown as the incarnate materials you earn instead — that's what the log actually records.)
- **The Play Log reads live and walks you through setup.** Once you pick an account it now updates on its own as you play (a "live" marker shows it's watching), so you don't have to keep clicking refresh. A built-in guide spells out the one-time in-game setup — make a chat tab named "Companion", add all channels to it, and turn on ``/logchat`` — so the only thing you have to remember is turning the log on. If there's no chat log for the day, the app says so and tells you how to start it. The opening screen is now framed simply: turn your sessions into *your* stats, all private and local — with any future community sharing kept as a separate choice. A plain privacy note spells out the promise: the tool only ever handles game data (prices, drops, stats), never your real name, email, location, IP, or account login, and never anything about the other players in your chat log.
- **The Play Log now asks before touching anything.** It read game files without asking and without saying what happens to the data — against this app's own rules. Now the section opens with a plain statement: what it reads (the chat logs your game writes), what you get (insights), and the promise — everything stays on this computer, nothing is uploaded or shared, and any future optional sharing will be a separate, clearly labeled, anonymous opt-in. Until you click "Enable the Play Log", the app doesn't even look at the game's folders. "No thanks" is remembered and reversible.

- **Fixed: the Play Log could dead-end.** Clicking "Read new log entries" before choosing an account replaced the account choices with an error message that told you to pick an account — with nothing left to pick. Now the read button simply doesn't exist until you're watching an account (it appears the moment you pick one), errors always bring the choices back, and the account choices look like buttons (" Watch filofinfain") instead of plain text.

0.12.6 — July 5, 2026

- **The Play Log (first cut).** A new full-width section at the bottom of the app reads your in-game chat logs (type ``/logchat`` in game once to start writing them) and turns them into insight — no raw log ever shown. Pick which account to watch (multi-account players choose their main), hit "Read new log entries" after a session, and get: session totals (XP, influence in/out, merits, defeats), progress (level-ups, badges), and your recent haul with keep-vs-convert/sell verdicts on every drop. Reading is incremental — only new lines since last time. The line formats are provisional until validated against real logs, and the tool says so: it reports how much it parsed and shows any data-looking lines it didn't recognize, so early users help perfect it.

0.12.5 — July 5, 2026

- **Power trays now follow the community standard** (researched from player forums):
Tray 1 is your active rotation — openers, then the single-target chain in slots 1-3 (the muscle-memory keys), then AoEs and cones, with the nuke pinned at the end. Tray 2 is mid-fight clicks — self-buffs, then heals, then endurance recovery grouped together at the end. Tray 3 is set-and-forget — toggles in switch-on order (your armors first, then pools), utility, and Rest parked last. Tray 4 is travel and sprints, deliberately away from the combat keys. The same kind of power lands in the same place on every character, so your muscle memory transfers between alts — the way experienced players actually set up their bars.
- **The Incarnates brick.** Your six incarnate choices (the solver's recommendations, or your own picks) now live in a card of their own — same shape as the in-game power trays and docked right above them, with the real in-game incarnate icons (family art + rarity ring) and the full ability name on hover. Slots you haven't filled show as dashed placeholders.
- **Every IO icon now shows its level.** Set pieces the optimizer slots (and ones you pick by hand) carry the level to buy or craft them at — the set's maximum, so a Cloud Senses piece reads 30, an Achilles' Heel proc 20, premium sets 50 — right under the icon, the same way common IOs already did.
- **Procs are named properly.** Slots the proc pass fills used to read just "Annihilation: proc" — they now carry the real piece name ("Annihilation: Chance for Res Debuff"), so you know exactly what to buy.
- **Ctrl+Z undoes your last edit.** Mis-clicked a slot? One keystroke takes it back — same as the Undo button (power picks, slot changes, enhancement swaps, pool changes). Typing in a text box keeps its normal Ctrl+Z.

0.12.4 — July 4, 2026

- ****Level 1 always satisfies the creation requirement: one primary power AND one secondary power****, each from that set's first two — the basics come before anything else, on every archetype (same treatment as the epic-pool prerequisite rule). A Poison/Sonic Defender's level 1 is Shriek/Scream + Alkaloid/Envenom; Envenom-and-Alkaloid-both-at-1 can't happen anymore, anywhere it's displayed.
- **Old saves fix themselves.** A character saved by an earlier version could carry an impossible level-1 arrangement that survived every update because it was stored with the build. The app now re-checks the pick order every time it recalculates and quietly corrects it — open the build and it's right, no re-solve needed.

0.12.3 — July 4, 2026

- **Only one copy of the app can run.** Launching Hero Companion while it's already running now just opens the running copy's page instead of silently starting a second (or third) hidden copy on another port — the cause of "the app shows no difference after an update" reports: the browser was talking to a leftover old copy the whole time. After a self-update, any leftover old copies are shut down so the new version is the one you see.
- ****Fixed: a generated build's pick levels were dropped when loading an AI-designed tier****, so the build grid fell back to naive level badges (Alkaloid AND Envenom both shown at level 1). The seated pick levels now survive the load.

0.12.2 — July 4, 2026

- **Fixed: slots the game could never grant.** An enhancement slot is earned at a specific level and can only be placed in a power you already have — so a power picked at level 49 can hold at most 4 slots (its free one plus the 3 earned at 50), and the 47 + 49 picks share just 6. The optimizer now seats heavily-slotted powers earlier in the pick order, re-solves with tighter budgets when even reordering can't fit (dense melee epics), and the validator calls out any hand-made arrangement the game would refuse ("picked at level 49 — it can hold at most 4 slots").
- **Smoother one-click updates.** The tab you click "Update now" in simply becomes the new version when the install finishes — the app no longer opens a duplicate tab while the old one lingers on the old version. (If that tab was closed, a fresh one still opens after a short wait.)
- **Level 1 is now framed as character creation.** In game your level-1 powers are one of the first two powers of your primary AND one of the first two of your secondary (verified against 2,255 master builds) — the plan now always seats a legal creation pair at level 1, the leveling walk says which choice was made and what the other option was, and the validator flags a build that skipped both of a set's first two powers.

0.12.1 — July 4, 2026

- **The decorative frame corners are gone.** The hero/villain identity now lives entirely in the color themes; the app uses the full window edge to edge.
- **Fixed: epic-pool pets taken without their prerequisites.** The game requires two other powers from an epic pool before its top-tier powers (Ice Elemental, Summon Spiderlings...) and one before the mid tier — the optimizer now takes the lower powers first, the search respects the ladder, and the validator counts precisely ("requires 2 other Ice Mastery powers — this build has 1").
- **Fixed: inherent powers shown as picks.** Health, Stamina, and other invariants are granted automatically by the game — the respec order no longer tells you to "take" them at a level (they get their own "automatic" footer line with slot counts), and their cards wear an "auto" badge instead of a level. Real picks' derived levels no longer shift to make room for them.

0.12.0 — July 4, 2026

The layout release — a complete redesign around one idea: a tight, horizontal, Sidekick-shaped workspace where every block fits snugly and every gap holds useful information.

- **The powers wall:** your build is a grid of uniform icon cards — power icon, name, level badge, enhancement icons with IO levels — flowing in pick order. No columns, no holes.
- **The build summary course:** beneath the wall, three equal bricks — Build Vitals (a labeled DEF/RES table plus recharge/recovery/HP/DPS), active Set Bonuses with stack counts and rule-of-five warnings, and the Uniques Carried checklist.
- **One tight masthead:** identity and icon-only actions in a single 40px strip.
- **Power Info panel:** click any power's name and a detail column opens on the right — type, availability, endurance cost, cast time, live damage/DPA/cycled-DPS (proc contributions included), allowed enhancement categories, and what's slotted in it right now. Numbers update with every change.
- **Horizontal-first layout:** character setup (archetype, sets, pools, epic, incarnates) is a compact left rail with Stats and the Build Assistant stacked beneath it; the powers icon grid owns the entire wide side. The masthead is one tight strip — identity, vitals, icon-only actions — that stays pinned as you scroll.
- **No AI anywhere.** The panel is simply the Build Assistant — deterministic presets, goals, and instant Solve. (The AI seam still exists for those who bring their own key, but it's opt-in and invisible otherwise.)
- **The build is now an icon grid** (Sidekick-style): taken powers appear as compact cards — power icon, name, level badge — with their slotted enhancements as an icon row (IO level under each), arranged in three level columns (1–12 / 14–28 / 30–49). Add-power choices moved below the build. Same clicks as before: click a slot to change it, right-click to clear.
- **Overview bar:** your build's vitals — typed and positional defense, resistance, recharge, HP, ST/AoE DPS — in one color-coded line that stays visible while you scroll. Green means you've hit the current-meta mark.
- **Tighter layout:** on wide screens the stats and controls panels sit side by side

(three columns total), paddings and text are denser — much more of the build fits in one view.

- During a one-click update, the old browser tab now says plainly that the app reopens in a new tab and this one can be closed — and it refreshes itself into the new version the moment you look at it (browsers throttle background tabs, which is why it previously seemed stuck on the old version).

0.11.1 — July 3, 2026

- **The optimizer now completes winter sets to 6 pieces** when typed defense is the goal — the big fire/cold defense bonuses the master builder flagged as missed are now chased properly (typed-defense targets carry full priority in the solver).
- **Wizard-built kits include procs by default.** A freshly generated build has no slotting to "preserve", so the proc pass now always runs on it.

0.11.0 — July 3, 2026

The master-class release — the optimizer went to school on 4,000+ builds shared by one of the community's best builders, plus his direct coaching.

- **Damage procs are now priced.** The engine computes each slotted %Damage proc's real contribution (PPM math: recharge, cast time, area factor), so the optimizer can genuinely trade set bonuses against procs — the core trade of the current meta.
- **Current-meta defense targets.** Presets now aim for ~35% Smashing/Lethal/Fire/Cold (typed) defense — or 35% Melee/Ranged/AoE for positional-armor characters — with the freed slots buying damage. Want the old 45% style? Put "classic softcap" in your goal. (Fire farm keeps its hard 45% fire floor — farms are still farms.)
- **Hasten gets 2 slots, never 3** — the third recharge IO is worth ~13% of face value after diminishing returns. A wasted slot, now unwasted.
- **One-click updates** — "Update now" downloads and installs the new version for you; the app closes, updates, and restarts itself. No more trips to the download page.
- Model v24; scoring is stamped, so older champion scores aren't compared to new ones.

0.10.1 — July 3, 2026

- **Fixed: power tray icons missing in the installed app.** Three data files (power icons, the proc catalog, incarnate magnitudes) were loaded with a path that only worked when running from source — in the packaged app they silently loaded empty. The tray now shows real power icons, and the solver's proc pass has its full catalog back.
- **The app finds your in-game saves for you.** After ``/build_save_file`` in game, click "Find my characters for me" — Hero Companion scans the usual Homecoming install locations, lists every character save it finds (newest first), and imports on click. Unusual install? Paste your game folder once and it's remembered. The manual file picker remains as a fallback.

0.10.0 — July 3, 2026

The installer release — Hero Companion now behaves like a proper Windows app.

- **Real installer:** download `HeroCompanion-Setup-0.10.0.exe`, run it, done. It installs to a standard location, offers a desktop icon, adds a Start Menu entry, registers in Add/Remove Programs with a working uninstaller, and upgrades in place. (The portable zip still exists for folder-preferring folks.)
- **No more console window:** the app runs in the background with a tray icon (the lime pulse, next to your clock). Right-click it to open the app or quit. Closing the browser tab no longer strands a mystery window.
- **Updates button in the header** — check for updates on demand, whatever you answered at startup.
- Your saves live in %APPDATA%\HeroCompanion as always — installing, upgrading, or uninstalling never touches your characters.

0.9.1 — July 3, 2026

- **Update prompts (opt-in):** on first run the app asks once whether to check for updates at startup. Say yes and new releases show an "Update now / Remind me later" banner; say no and only the manual footer button ever checks.
- **Standalone builds are truly AI-free:** no more "AI: checking..." chip or "Ask Claude" box that could never work without a paid key. The panel is now the Build Assistant — presets, goals, and instant Solve, all fully offline. (Advanced: set HC_AI=1 with your own Claude key to re-enable the assistant.)
- **The app has its own icon** — the lime pulse badge, in the taskbar where it belongs, instead of the generic packaging icon.
- **Fixed:** the build wizard could clip its lower content on short windows with no way to scroll; it now scrolls within the dialog.
- **Fixed:** launching a second copy (or anything else holding port 5000) no longer kills the app — it moves to the next free port and says so.

0.9.0 — July 3, 2026

The "Hero Companion" release — the app has a name, a face, its papers in order, and a PC body to live in.

- **Standalone PC version:** Hero Companion now packages as a Windows executable — no Python, no setup; run it and the app opens in your browser. Your saves live in %APPDATA%\HeroCompanion.
- **Report a bug:** one click opens a pre-filled report (versions auto-included) on the project's GitHub page. Nothing is ever sent without your click.
- **Submit champion:** beat a shipped champion build? Export your candidate and post

it to the submission queue — verified wins become the next shipped champion, with credit.

- **Check for updates:** compares your version against the latest GitHub release.

Never automatic, never forced.

- **Hero/Villain reskin:** the app is now *Hero Companion* (or *Villain Companion* — flip alignment from the banner). Themed corners, colors, and cards; your choice is remembered.

- **Soldiers & Widows leveled honestly:** the level-1-to-50 walk now follows the real VEAT career — base powers only until the mandatory level-24 respect, then the full re-place order with your Crab/Bane or Night Widow/Fortunata branch.

- **Kheldians leveled honestly:** single-path sets auto-select, inherent flight means "no extra travel" by default, and the epic-pool step is gone (they don't get one).

- **Enhancement Converter planner + haul appraiser:** paste your drops (recipes included) and get keep/convert/sell verdicts with concrete converter paths and merit costs.

- **Origin pool rule enforced:** only one of Sorcery / Experimentation / Force of Will / Gadgetry / Utility Belt per build — the optimizer and validator both know the game won't allow a second.

- **Optimizer explores all pools:** Sorcery, Experimentation, and friends are now real candidates in the search, not just Fighting/Leadership/Speed/Leaping.

- **Terms, License, Credits:** CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 (free & noncommercial forever), Terms of Use, and full credits — including Guyver [SoV] of Sovereign, whose master builds were this tool's calibration standard.

- **This help system:** the Help button and this document.

Earlier (the road here)

- Physics/encounter model v23: wiki-verified to-hit, resistance, purple patch, mez protection, and archvillain rules; role-weighted scoring; scenario coverage.
- Deep optimizer: full-neighborhood search that runs to convergence with honest certificates, warm-started from champion builds, learning across runs.
- Leveling companion: per-level walk of the exact Homecoming schedule with cost-smart enhancement advice, deviation tracking, and end-game re-fit.
- Mids Reborn import/export compatibility.